

Intelligence is...

Ever since Homo sapiens learnt to communicate with each other, the one common driving force behind all you see around you is knowledge. Unlike every other species around us, mankind is hungry – too hungry, some would say. All the science and technology we take for granted today didn't exist 50 or 100 years ago, except in the realms of science fiction, perhaps. Actually, sci-fi is perhaps our greatest gift, because someone has to dream it before mankind makes it.

Mankind has shown interest in several areas of science – understanding our world, exploring space, and giving us an insight into just how miniscule and irrelevant we all are in the grand scheme of things...the one thing that still alludes us is an understanding of ourselves. Whether you're more inclined to believe Darwin or your religious books, one thing is for sure, we still can't explain ourselves as easily as Mathematics, Physics and Chemistry can explain the world we live in. Sure we can bring the recently dead back to life, or put one person's spare parts into another and save lives, but even medical science loses its exactness when it comes to the human brain. The human mind, to be more precise, or our intelligence is what makes each one of us as unique as our DNA.

Despite all the advances in medicine that you read about, such as in stem cell research, we're about as close to building a living breathing human from simple chemicals as we are to sending probes to UDFj-39546284 (the farthest known galaxy we've spotted – a mere 13.2 billion light years away). OK, perhaps we exaggerate a tad, but it's a fact that when it comes to understanding what makes us intelligent, we're still clueless... or are we?

Sure we may not be able to rebuild a working human brain from chemicals, but we may not be as ridiculously far from building a machine that can mimic one!

But what's with this verbose and rather abstract introduction, you ask? Well you're the one who picked up a Fast Track to Artificial Intelligence to